An Interaction Approach to Organizational Buying Behavior

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This paper develops guidelines for marketing and purchasing managers by concentrating on the interaction strategies they use in their relationships with buyers and sellers. Buyer-seller relationships can be independent, interdependent, or dependent; these different types arise from the interplay of the strategies chosen by the buyer and the seller. Buyers use competitive, cooperative, or command interaction strategies, and the problem of understanding the key variables which influence buyer behavior is alleviated by concentrating on those which determine the buyer's choice of strategy.

Although interest in and research on organizational buying have increased over the past two decades, few empirical generalizations have emerged to provide specific guidelines for management action. This conclusion by Wind and Thomas [28] reinforces the view expressed by Wind [27] in the first edition of *Review of Marketing*. This paper attempts to fill this gap by developing the interaction approach associated with the International Marketing and Purchasing (IMP) Group.

The lack of empirical generalizations may be due to the complexity of available models [17, 22, 23]. The popular Webster and Wind model placed great emphasis on analysis of the buying center, the buying decision process, and the buying situation. In practice, this tripartite analysis has proved difficult to perform because the interpersonal process at work in a buying center are hard to unravel, the stages of the buying decision process are hard to distinguish, and even the distinction between "new buy" and "modified rebuy" is not always clear. Industrial marketing managers are well aware that their jobs are complex.

In order to guide marketing managers and resolve the research problems, attention has focused on discrete buying decisions. In consequence, research has concentrated on new buy situations in which discrete decisions are easy to identify. Routine response behavior, which Möller [17] claims is more common, has been neglected. In other words, the emphasis has been on the process of discrete purchase decisions rather than on the development of strategies for the management of a pattern of relationships over long periods of time.

In contrast, this paper stems from research in areas where long-term stable relationships are important, as attested to by many authorities [2, 9, 11, 26]. In such situations,

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the study of discrete purchase decisions is less relevant than the study of the patterns of interaction between buyers and their supply markets.

This paper results from an intensive two-year research study designed to complement previous work carried out by the IMP Group. The original IMP research project [12] was an international, cross-sectional study aimed at understanding the nature of buyer-seller relationships. Some 300 companies covering 15 different industries in 5 countries were involved. The IMP researchers placed great emphasis on a comparative analysis of how suppliers and customers in various product technologies and end-use industries handled their relationships with counterpart companies in domestic and foreign markets. In contrast, the research study on which this paper is based focused on 167 trading relationships in the packaging industry in Europe. Both sides of the buyer-seller relationships were researched, and by examining one industry, the product technology variable in the relationships was held constant.

To understand the trading relationships, this paper classifies buyer-seller relationships and identifies the common strategies which buyers and sellers use in their interactions. This classification enables attention to focus on the critical variables which give rise to the different strategies. In addition, useful managerial guidelines are developed which assist sellers in choosing a strategy in response to the strategy being used by their counterpart.

Classification of Buyer-Seller Relationships

The classification adopted is based on the three types of governance structure proposed by Williamson [25] for commercial transactions. Campbell and Cunningham [4] provide an extensive review of other approaches to the classification of buyer-seller relationships. Williamson's approach arises from his work on markets and hierarchies [24] and is linked to Ouchi's [18, 19] concern with ensuring equity in relationships.

Equity is assured in many exchanges by the market mechanism. A fair price is established by competitive market forces, and the price itself contains most of the information needed by the parties. Such relationships are independent. However, where the exchange is contingent on uncertain future events, assessment of price is very difficult. Nevertheless, the requirement for equity remains and, for this reason, a bureaucratic, or hierarchical, relationship is preferred. The perception of equity depends on a social agreement that the bureaucratic system has the legitimate authority to decide what is fair. In these relationships, one party is dependent on the other.

Intermediate between the market and bureaucratic mechanisms is the clan mechanism, which Ouchi claims can also ensure equity. Equity based on clan control involves a long process of socialization, which develops common values and beliefs. The evidence for long-term relationships and source loyalty suggests that the clan form, an interdependent relationship, is common in buyer-seller relationships.

Independent, dependent, and interdependent relationships arise in different situations. For example, independence arises when the buyer plays the market and the seller has plenty of potential customers. Marketing and purchasing strategies in these commodity-type markets are competitive. Independence also arises in a buyer's market, in which there are many competitive sellers, and in a seller's market, where there are many buyers. On the other hand, interdependence arises when both parties approach the relationship with a strategy of cooperation. They are both willing to establish a long-term relationship, to exchange information openly, and to trust each other. Finally, a dependent relationship results from the dominance one party exerts over the other.

Marketing or purchasing strategies which result when one party has a dominant posi-

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tion of strength are called *command* strategies. Thus, the independent, interdependent, and dependent types of relationships result from the interplay of interaction strategies, classified here as competitive, cooperative, and command. Campbell and Cunningham have described similar classifications developed by other researchers [1, 6, 7, 10, 12]. The interplay of these strategies leads directly to the nine-cell matrix in Figure 1.

In Figure 1 there are three cells with independent relationships, one with interdependent relationships, two with dependent relationships, and three labeled "Mismatch." The typical strategies and responses which apply to these different situations are discussed in the final section of this paper.

Thus, in place of the Webster and Wind classification of buying situations into new buy, modified rebuy, and straight rebuy, Figure 1 proposes a new typology of buyer-seller relationships. In this typology, the buying situation is determined by the interplay of marketing and purchasing strategies, which are themselves determined by a variety of other factors. Therefore, a model is required which incorporates the interplay of marketing and purchasing strategies and identifies the conditions which determine their choice.

Interaction Model

Neither the Sheth [22] model nor the Webster and Wind [23] model fulfills the above-stated need to incorporate the interplay of marketing and purchasing strategies and their determinants. The Sheth model is mainly concerned with the psychological aspects of individual buyer behavior. However, in addition to individual factors, Sheth introduces

Figure 1. Classification of buyer–seller relationships.

Purchasing Strategies	Marketing Strategies: Competitive	Cooperative	Command
Competitive	1 Independent Perfect Market	2 Mismatch	3 Independent Seller's Market
Cooperative	4 Mismatch	5 Interdependent Domesticated Market	6 Dependent Captive Market
Command	7 Independent Buyer's Market	8 Dependent Subcontract Market	9 Mismatch

product-specific and company-specific factors, as well as the outcome of previous decisions and situational factors, which he says are too varied and broad to analyze in detail. These factors converge in a "black box" called the *industrial buying process*.

Although it is more comprehensive and considers four sets of variables–environmental, organizational, interpersonal, and individual–the Webster and Wind model also poses problems. The desire for comprehensiveness leads to the inclusion of every possible influence, which makes the model difficult to use. Laczniak and Murphy [15] have cautioned against a "laundry list of possible influences."

Another disadvantage of both models is that they concentrate on the buyer's side. Scant attention is paid to the seller's influence on buyer behavior. By contrast, the interaction model developed by the IMP Group [12] stresses the interaction between two active parties, and the model proposed here (see Figure 2) gives equal weight to buyer and seller characteristics.

This model goes beyond the work of the IMP Group by introducing the concept of *interaction strategies*, whose interplay affects the interaction mechanisms and interaction atmosphere in a two-way exchange. Figure 2 also emphasizes a different set of variables from those in the IMP model.

Three groups of variables are shown–the characteristics of the buyer, the supplier, and the product. The characteristics of the buyer and the supplier are divided into three sets representing the industry, the company, and the individuals or buying center members. One could argue that the characteristics of the two industries should be separated from those of the two companies and the two groups of individuals. However, the strong interconnection between company strategy and industry structure suggests the need to keep them together [20]. The impact of general environmental factors is presumed to take place through changes in the characteristics of the buyer's and/or supplier's industry. This has the advantage that the environments of both buyer and seller are explicitly considered, and it avoids the weakness of the IMP model, which includes only an aggregated environment.

A full list of the variables considered in the model is given in Table 1. There is no attempt to be comprehensive. Rather, variables are included which research indicates cause a particular buyer or seller to choose a strategy.

Product Characteristics

Different writers have used different attributes in their attempts to classify products. Robinson, Faris, and Wind [21] proposed the three buy classes. Cardozo [5] suggests a classification by product use, degree of standardization, and the product's importance to the buyer. Other writers have also used characteristics of the product's importance to the buyer [17, 20]. Homse [13] classifies products according to their complexity, and Williamson [25] concentrates on the three key dimensions of frequency of transaction, switching costs, and uncertainty.

Frequency of transaction distinguishes between the purchase of capital goods required infrequently and components and raw materials delivered more regularly. Where the transaction occurs frequently, the relationships are likely to be more interdependent. At the other extreme, the infrequent purchase of standard capital equipment is often dealt with by competitive tenders.

Switching costs are the costs incurred in changing suppliers. This dimension incorporates the ideal of standardization because standard products will normally have lower switching costs than customized products. The higher the switching costs, the greater the

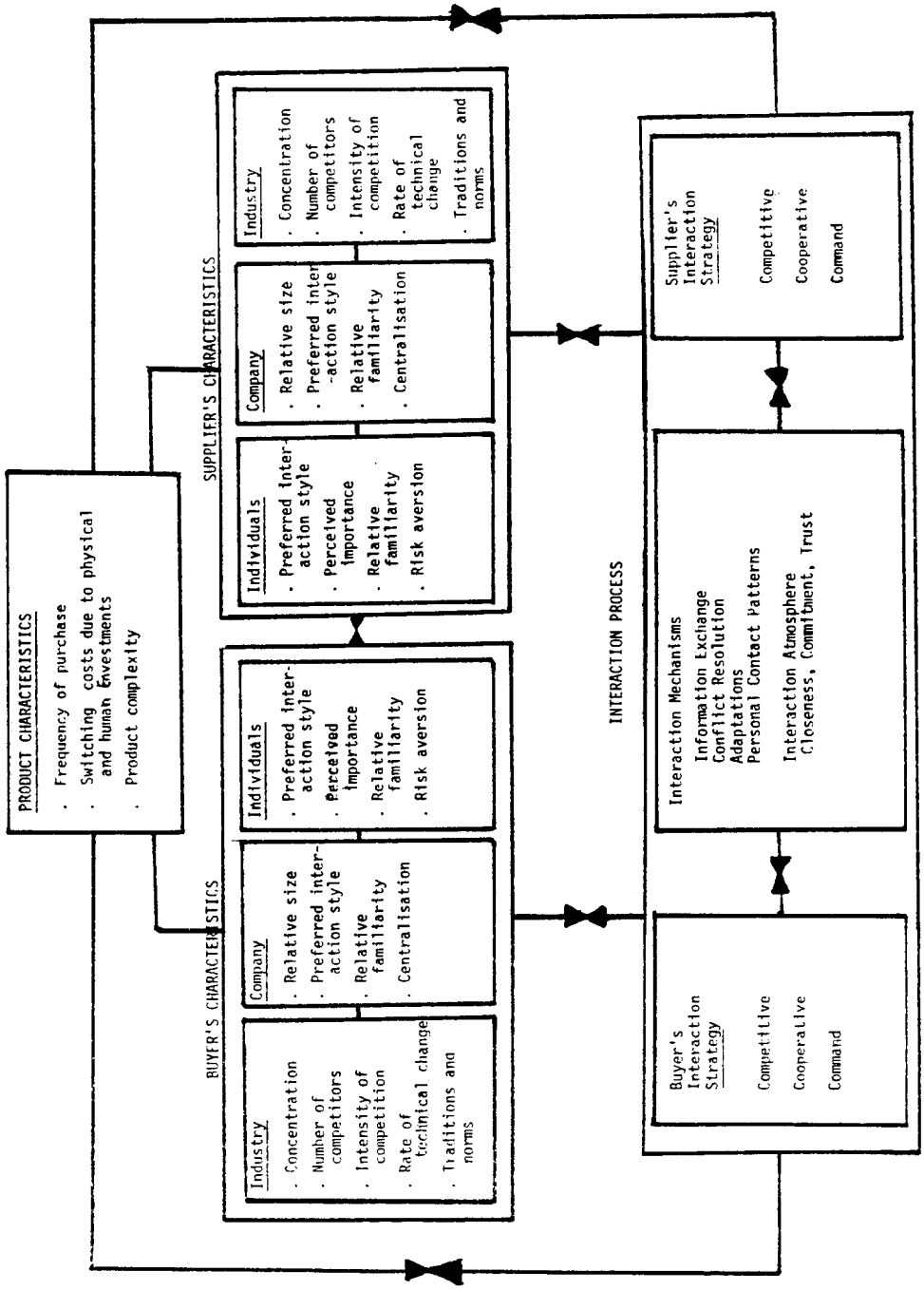

Figure 2. Buyer-seller interaction model.

Table 1. Interaction Variables

Buyer's Side	Interaction Variables	Supplier's Side
Product	Frequency of purchase Switching costs due to physical and human investments Product complexity	Product
Industry characteristics	Concentration Number of alternative partners Intensity of competition Rate of technical change Traditions and norms	Industry characteristics
Company characteristics	Relative size Preferred interaction style Relative familiarity Centralization of purchasing	Company characteristics
Individual characteristics	Relative familiarity Preferred interaction style Perceived importance of the purchase (sale) Risk aversion	Individual characteristics

specific investments which each party has made in the relationship. Switching costs can result from human as well as physical investments. Salesmen and buyers invest in getting to know each other's business. Table 2 summarizes the main sources of switching costs between industrial buyers and marketers.

While switching costs are a function of the product in the sense that some products must be more closely adapted to the customer's needs than others, they also reflect the type of relationship that exists. In an independent relationship, a buyer pursuing a competitive strategy in a particular supply market will try to minimize switching costs to avoid being tied to one supplier. The aim is to standardize purchases, and the buyer tends to have a technical staff to solve problems. On the other hand, a buyer pursuing a cooperative strategy is more ready to pay switching costs in return for joint efforts to find the best solution to his or her problem. Such a buyer has a relatively smaller technical staff, and is willing to cooperate on development work and to accept special products. In general, the higher the switching costs, the greater the tendency for cooperative or command strategies to be used.

The third dimension, product complexity, is preferred by Williamson's uncertainty. Homse [13] has identified six types of product complexity. A product has *functional complexity* when it consists of numerous parts and subassemblies. *Manufacturing complexity* is straightforward, but *specification complexity* refers to products which require extensive trial periods [13, p. 150]. Products have a high *application complexity* due either to the extensive training required before the buyer knows how to use them or to the uncertainty inherent in the customer's pattern of demand. *Commercial complexity* refers to transactions involving complicated commercial arrangements, such as stage payments, penalty clauses, and performance bonds. Finally, *political complexity* applies to purchases which Lehmann and O'Shaughnessey [16] call "political problem products"—purchases for which different factions will be for and against. In general, the more complex the product, the more interdependent the buyer/seller relationships.

Table 2. Source of Switching Costs in Buyer-Seller Relationships

Activity	Source of Switching Costs	
	Supplier	Customer
Product introduction	Supplying prototype and test data	Testing a new product
	Training customer's staff	Training own staff
Production	Changing materials, design, processing, or production equipment to meet customer's needs	Changing product, design, or production methods to accommodate the supplier
	Special quality control	Special quality control
	Especially rapid production	
Logistics	Special stock-holding and delivery requirements	Special warehousing and handling
Product development and technical service	Time needed to get to know customer's problems and technical staff	Time needed to understand supplier's technical resources and staff
Buying, selling, and administration	Time required to get to know the customer, his or her staff, and ways of doing business; special documentation and procedures	Time required to get to know supplier, his or her staff, and ways of doing business; special documentation and procedures

Industry Characteristics

The variables proposed in Figure 2 are concentration, number of competitors, intensity of competition, rate of technical change, and traditions and norms. These variables are similar to those proposed by Robinson, Faris, and Wind [21, pp. 119-212] in their discussion of the key characteristics of the supplying industry which influence buyer behavior. Their variables are the number of potential suppliers, the type of competition (whether price or nonprice), the threat of material or parts shortages, the traditional ways of doing business, social-political-economic conditions, and significant events such as technological breakthroughs.

The importance of concentration and the number of alternative partners was recognized by the IMP Group in their original formulation of the interaction model. They also included "dynamism" as a variable, referring to the heterogeneity of the supply market. Buyers in dynamic markets or buyers purchasing from dynamic markets, in which there is a high rate of technical change, tend to use competitive buying strategies to protect themselves from being tied to a partner who cannot keep pace. Most writers recognize that the traditions and norms of each industry have an important influence on buyer behavior, and these represent the final variable. Some industries, such as automobile manufacturing, have a reputation for using competitive buying approaches, which they are only now beginning to change [3].

Company Characteristics

The interplay of marketing and purchasing strategies and the mechanisms and atmosphere of the relationship depend on the characteristics of the parties involved. The IMP

researchers proposed that the technology, size, structure, and strategy of the company be considered [12, pp. 18-20]. Some of these variables are included in Figure 2.

The relative size of the two companies is obviously important; command buying is more likely to occur when the buyer is larger than the supplier. *Relative familiarity* refers to how well the two companies know each other relative to their knowledge of other partners. Familiarity resulting from many years of trading together, as found in mature markets, favors cooperative purchasing.

Familiarity is also important with respect to technology and the costs and ways of doing business. The buyer who is familiar with the technology of the supplier and knows the supplier's costs is in a powerful position. This buyer can either use a command strategy or, where several alternatives exist, adopt a competitive purchasing approach.

The interviews on which this paper is based also revealed that companies tend to have a preferred interaction style. One well-known U.S. consumer company operating in Europe invariably uses a competitive purchasing strategy. In contrast, another U.S. company has a policy of preferring interdependent relationships with one or two key suppliers for each class of purchase.

The last interaction variable covers organization. Möller [17] distinguishes between departmental and company organization, recognizing that the structure, managerial style, and organizational climate of individual departments, as well as those of the company as a whole, must be taken into account. Möller identifies many variables but does not indicate which ones he considers most important. Research in the packing industry suggests that the extent of centralization in the buying department is a key variable. For simplicity, this is the only variable included in the model.

Individual Characteristics

A relationship must ultimately depend on the interaction of the individuals who participate. In complex interactions,several members of a buying center interact with their opposite numbers in the supplying company.

Understanding of the patterns of behavior between members of a buying center is still rudimentary [14], and only recently has work been done on the interaction between the buying center and the sales team [8, 13]. Cunningham and Turnbull [8] point out that interpersonal contacts fulfill different roles in different circumstances and that they vary widely in intensity and style. Indeed, individuals in some companies have preferred interaction styles. An individual's preference depends on his or her psychology. The IMP Group emphasizes motivation and experience. Möller includes all of these factors. In addition, he includes buying-related knowlege and interindividual behavior. Again, there are too many variables. In the interests of simplicity, only four variables are included in Figure 2: preferred interaction style, perceived importance of the sale or purchase, relative familiarity, and risk aversion.

If the buyer has a number of alternatives and the product is perceived as important, then a competitive buying approach is more likely to prevail. High relative familiarity indicates the close, cooperative relationship of the buying center members with suppliers' sale teams.

Summary

Figure 2 develops the IMP Group's interaction model by introducing the interaction strategies of the buyer and seller. It identifies the main variables which determine the

Table 3. Conditions Favoring Different Buying Strategies

	Competitive Buying	Cooperative Buying	Command Buying
Product characteristics	Low or high frequency of purchase	High frequency of purchase	High frequency of purchase
	Low switching costs (standardized product)	High switching costs (customized product)	High switching costs
	Product performance can be precisely specified	Product performance difficult to specify	Product can be specified but is customized
Industry characteristics	Supplier's industry fragmented	Both industries are concentrated	Buyer's industry concentrated but supplier's industry fragmented
	Intense price competition among suppliers	Stable competitive situation in each industry	Average level of competition
	High rate of technical change	Low rate of technical change	Low rate of technical change
	Tradition of competitive buying	Tradition of cooperative buying	Tradition of command buying
Company characteristics	Buying company is larger than supplier	Both companies are similar in size	Buying company much larger than supplier
	Buying company prefers competitive buying	Both companies seek a cooperative relationship	Buying company prefers to dominate supplier's costs and technology
	Buying company lacks familiarity with the product (new buy)	Both companies are familiar with each other and respect each other's technical knowledge	Buying company is familiar with suppliers
	Centralized buying organization	Organizational structures are similar	Buyer has more professional organization than supplier
Individual characteristics	Product perceived as important by buyer	Product is perceived as important by both parties	Product is important to buyer
	Buyer is not risk averse for this purchase	Buyer is risk averse for this purchase	Buyer is risk averse for this purchase
	Individuals who interact do not know each other well	Individuals who interact know each other	Individuals know each other personally
	Buyer prefers competitive buying approach	Both buyer and seller prefer a cooperative relationship	Buyer prefers a command strategy and supplier accepts cooperative role

choice of strategy of the buyer or seller. Three groups of variables are discussed: the product and, for both buyer and seller, the characteristics of their industry, their company, and the individuals involved in the interaction. Table 1 identified 16 variables of prime importance. Table 3 summarizes the above discussion and identifies the conditions favoring competitive, cooperative, and command purchasing strategies.

Management Implications

Figure 1 identified six common types of relationships. Marketing and purchasing managers can readily identify the type of situation they are facing. Table 4 indicates the typical strategies and responses used in these situations. In a buyer's market, there are normally many suppliers and only a few powerful buyers. The buyers request quotations or put out competitive tenders; their approach is to "play the market." Suppliers must submit quotes and try to gain a competitive advantage by obtaining cost leadership or by differentiating.

In a seller's market, there are a few large suppliers and many small buyers. The sellers may see the advantage of forming a cartel to maintain prices. In this event, buyers may collaborate with other buyers and try to break the cartel, or at least exchange information to improve their bargaining position. Monopoly suppliers have different problems. Their marketing strategies are frequently directed at legitimizing their position and placating customers with elaborate complaint procedures and information campaigns. Thus, at this general level, some management insights are possible. More specific guidelines for marketing and purchasing management now follow.

Table 4. Marketing and Purchasing Strategies and Responses in Different Types of Markets

	Typical Strategies and Responses	
Type of Market	Marketing	Purchasing
Perfect market	Take it or leave it Try to obtain lowest cost Try to differentiate	Play the market Standardize requirements
Seller's market	Take it or leave it Form a cartel Legitimize, placate Standardize the product	Accept gracefully Buy jointly Exchange information with other buyers Complain, agitate Encourage competitors
Buyer's market	Competitive bidding Try to obtain lowest cost	Put out tenders Play the market
Domesticated market	Customize, specialize, differentiate, innovate	Adapt, cooperate, work together
Captive market	Educate the buyer	Learn from the supplier
Subcontract market	Learn from the buyer	Educate the supplier

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Table 5. Buying Characteristics and Buying Strategies

Buying Characteristic	Buying Strategy	
	Competitive	Cooperative
Number of suppliers	Many	Few
Proportion of purchases held by main suppliers	Low	High
Number of new suppliers taken on recently	Several	Few
Proportion of business given to new suppliers	Moderate	Low
Willingness to accept special adaptations	Unwilling	Willing
Desire for standardization of the product	High	Average
Technical dependence on suppliers	Low	High
Emphasis in buying	Price	Service, quality

Marketing Management

First, the marketer must remember that buyers use more than one approach in a given supply market. Nevertheless, one approach usually predominates, and the marketer's own sales force can help to collect some simple data, such as those in Table 5, which will help to distinguish between competitive and cooperative buying strategies. Once the buying approach or strategy has been identified, clear guidelines for marketing strategies are available, as detailed in Table 6.

Table 6. Marketing Strategies to Match Different Buying Approaches

	Cooperative	Competitive	Command
Existing customers			
Pricing	Don't overcharge	Match market price	Negotiate prices
Customer service	Nothing is too much trouble	Competitive but no frills	At your service
Personal contacts	Frequent, including courtesy visits from senior managers	Regular visits	Ensure that personal relationships are maintained
Product development	Grasp all opportunities to work with the customer Stay ahead technically	Do what is required Beware of stealing of ideas	Work as required by the customer
New customers	Where competition is established, offer a major advantage, e.g., by innovation, or wait until there is a lapse by current competitors Beware of being exploited by a customer who has no intention of changing	Offer comparable price, service, and quality, and stress benefits of multiple sourcing	Offer facilities to make whatever is required; propose trial order

Marketing Strategies for Cooperative Customers. Cooperative customers require a lot of attention. They need reassurance that their decision to concentrate their purchases and put their faith in one or two suppliers is correct. To give this reassurance, senior management from the supplying company must visit these customers and take every opportunity to develop social changes. The service which cooperative customers receive needs to be excellent, and the supplier must stay ahead technically to justify this privileged position. Pricing is one of the most difficult areas with cooperative customers, since the marketer must recover operating costs but avoid overcharging lest this provide an opportunity for competitors to penetrate the account. The objective should be to use customers' cooperation to find ways to meet their needs, preferably over time. This could lead to reduced costs, and enable a marketer to supply at a competitive price and make a good margin. Marketers who take advantage of a cooperative customer's loyalty and charge an elevated price run the risk of permanently ruining the relationship if the customer realizes that he or she has been overcharged. Such an occurrence breaks the feeling of mutual dependence and shared objectives on which this type of relationship depends. Deprived of reassurance of equity in the relationship, the customer is likely to react sharply.

Knowledge of a customer's purchasing approach is very helpful when deciding which companies are the best prospects for future business. In mature markets, customers with cooperative purchasing strategies have, by definition, developed long-term relationships. These are difficult to penetrate unless the marketer can offer a significant price reduction or innovation which the existing supplier cannot match.

Marketers should be cautious about spending large sums in an effort to obtain business from such customers, who normally favor existing suppliers and are likely to give them an opportunity to match any new offers they receive. If the marketer has no significant advantage to offer, the only option is to wait until the customer is dissatisfied with the existing supplier or until there is a structural change such as a merger or takeover, which may sever existing links between personnel. The bonds with existing customers are also broken when there is a change in the customer's own market position. Such events provide good opportunities for the astute marketer.

Marketing Strategies for Competitive Customers. Customers with competitive purchasing strategies require different handling. Marketing costs and contracts with competitive customers must be kept to a minimum because their prime concern is price. Many suppliers know the frustration of losing an order to a lower-priced competitor. A careful balance has to be struck between the advantages of differentiating the product by providing additional services and the disadvantage of a price which is out of step with the market price. Resources may be better deployed in searching for production economies which will lower the price.

Companies with competitive purchasing strategies may be the easiest to obtain as new customers. Their interest can often be gained by offering a comparable, or preferably better, price, quality, and service. The marketer should stress the benefits of multiple sourcing.

Marketing Strategies for Companies with Command Purchasing. The company subject to a command purchasing strategy should also keep its marketing costs to a minimum. The supplier's role is to do the buyer's bidding, and the keys to success are flexibility, personal attention to the buying company's needs, and efficient production facilities. These are the points to stress in the search for new customers.

Conclusions

This paper sets out to overcome the problem that research on organizational buying behavior has yielded few guidelines for management action.

Marketing and purchasing behaviors are classified into three interaction strategies. The buying decision process is modeled as resulting from the interplay of these strategies, which in turn are influenced by the characteristics of the product, the buyer, and the seller. A multitude of variables influence buyer and seller behavior. Sixteen variables relevant to both buyers and sellers are incorporated in the model because they seem to be the most important in influencing the choice of interaction strategy. Although useful guidelines have been developed, research has been conducted only in the packaging industry, and additional research in other industries is now required.

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